

Doing philosophy with a water-lance: art and the future of embodied cognition

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Abstract

We take the approach developed by Rietveld and RAAAF to be a paradigm example of a much-needed development in embodied cognitive science: applying the insights gained into the nature of cognition back to embodied cognition itself, back to the practice of bodily engagements with our sociocultural environments. Rietveld's work is groundbreaking precisely because it stands almost alone as a prototype of this move: to raise embodiment from a mere content of our theorizing to the practical level of determining the form of our activity, including our scholarly activity. We describe some of our own artistic-scholarly work that follows similar principles.

Keywords

Embodied cognition, art installation, Heidegger, Habermas

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The work developed by Erik Rietveld (2019) and his collaborators at Rietveld Architecture-Art-Affordances (RAAAF) offers us, among other things, a new way of delimiting the boundaries of embodied cognition. It helps us take stock of its current state as a philosophy of cognitive science while simultaneously driving the movement beyond its present limitations. It invites us to explore the way we encounter and navigate meaning in our sociocultural environments – not in the metaphorical sense of intellectual reflection, but through the active perception of an *Umwelt* rendered unfamiliar through material artistic intervention (Feiten, 2020; Feiten et al., 2020).

We take the approach developed at RAAAF to be a paradigm example of a much-needed development in embodied cognitive science: applying the insights gained into the nature of cognition back to embodied cognition itself, back to the practice of bodily engagements with our sociocultural environments. If cognition is not an abstract algorithmic solution to a problem of representing information about a hidden external world, but the skilled and goal-directed engagement and intervention in an environment we inhabit through our bodies, why does the way we do (philosophy of) cognitive science largely fail to reflect this insight? Professor Rietveld's work is groundbreaking precisely because it stands almost alone as a prototype of this

move: to raise embodiment from a mere content of our theorizing to the practical level of determining the form of our activity, including our scholarly activity.

The three core principles outlined in Rietveld's inaugural lecture perfectly illustrate this achievement:

1. After escaping the lifeless, *ceteris paribus* abstraction of the lab, embodied cognition as a practice of artistic intervention encounters rich layers of meaning in the natural, cultural and social *Umwelten* inhabited by human and non-human meaning-makers.
2. Living subjects embody not just their own goals but also the drive to play. RAAAF explores how new technologies and artistic techniques enable the creation of material playgrounds, opening up spaces of affordances where new meanings emerge through free exploration and experimentation.
3. A radical openness towards different possible futures characterizes RAAAF's artistic practice. Innovation is not the outcome of theoretical problem-solving, but

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the spontaneous actualization of possibilities that could not have been planned in advance.

This bold departure from the confines of the ivory tower and into the shared social worlds of everyday life highlights the potential for embodied cognitive science to create positive impact beyond the narrow horizon of academia. From the hydro-demolition of WWII bunkers using a water-lance, to the slow transformation of sand into bio-cement by bacteria, RAAAF is pushing the envelope of material intervention, slicing straight through solid concrete and through our habits and expectations for navigating the world. Rietveld intends this 'genre of philosophical art installations' as a way of moving philosophy beyond the text and answering the question: 'Can academic philosophy be done non-discursively?' This same question lies at the heart of the Strange Tools Research Lab (STRL) at the University of Cincinnati.

Proceeding from Alva Noë's claim that artworks lead us to question our conventional practices and norms of engaging the world, including doing research, the Strange Tools Lab seeks to investigate and facilitate the processes whereby new tools emerge and render familiar relations and activities strange (Noë, 2016). Our methods include non-discursive practices such as art inquiry, brought into dialogue with neuroscience, cognitive science, engineering, design and philosophy. The aim for this new laboratory is to provide a space where scholars can create the infrastructure to understand, make, test and disseminate strange tools.

At the lab, we investigate how experiences with art and design can enhance public health and community engagement by inventing new tools that result from the convergence of the arts and sciences. To this end, we form interdisciplinary teams and develop mixed-methods for recording the qualitative aspects of experiencing strange tools, while also visualizing data in engaging and informative ways. The goal is to derive overarching communicative and visual strategies from

a series of varied projects at the point of convergence between visual arts, natural science and public health.

Two concrete projects have sketched the course for the Strange Tools Lab and serve as illustrations of the approach that is so in tune with Rietveld's work at RAAAF: *The Habermas Machine* and *Heidegger's Hammer*, both by Kristopher Holland (see Figures 1 and 2).

The Habermas Machine (2006–2012) is a conceptual art experience that both examines and promotes an experiential relation to Jürgen Habermas' grand theory for understanding human interaction (Habermas, 1981/1984). The central claim is that *The Theory of Communicative Action* can be experienced, reflected upon and practised when encountered within arts-based research. Habermas' description of how our everyday lives are founded by intersubjective experience, and caught up in certain normative, objective and subjective contexts is transformed through the method of conceptual art into a process of collaborative designing, enacting and articulating. This artistic reframing makes it possible to experience the communicative structure of knowledge and the ontological structure of intersubjectivity in a practice of non-discursive 'philosophy without text'.

The Habermas Machine opens up new possibilities for encounters with philosophy beyond the text, but also creates the framework and methods for his work to be understood, reflected upon and disseminated in new ways. Thus, this project as a strange tool reflects the spirit engulfing arts-based research in the 'double-bind' of theory as practice (Rolling, 2013). The act of researching is bound by a feedback loop in which both the design and experience of the inquiry spark epistemological transformations that render the outcome of our encounters unpredictable. This type of research structure speaks to a truly generative discourse from design to implementation and articulation of research outcomes. *Intersubjectivity*, *System* and *Lifeworld* are



Figure 1. Habermas Machine, Kristopher Holland (2006–2012).



Figure 2. Heidegger's Hammer, Kristopher Holland (2017–2020).

rendered palpable by foregrounding the ‘physical space’ of philosophical inquiry (Habermas, 1981/1987).

Heidegger's Hammer (2017–2020) is a project currently under construction which also uses strategies developed by *The Habermas Machine* to pedagogically investigate some of Heidegger's ideas (Heidegger, 1927/1962). This project investigates how philosophical outcomes can result from descriptive, explanatory and interpretive acts in the context of an encounter with conceptual art. These non-discursive experiences can generate new understandings of Heidegger's work through the process of making art. These two projects draw into question what philosophy is and how it is practised at a basic level. The normative Western methodology of philosophical inquiry as reading and writing is confronted with a radically embodied intervention that holds the potential to reconfigure established relationships between art, science and philosophy.

Central to both projects is the improvisatory architecture of the artistic encounter. The way in which the experience of conceptual art energizes a discourse and moves it forward is as unpredictable as human interactions themselves. The emergent practice of using conceptual art as the tool and method for gaining knowledge of complex philosophical notions is the kind of terra incognita that we hope to explore at the Strange Tools Lab. We take Erik Rietveld's work at RAAAF to be a trailblazing effort in this exciting new terrain of philosophy-practice at the interface between conceptual art and embodied cognitive science. Together, they are working to reshape the ways in which art is conceptualized and philosophy is practised.

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